SESSION 07

# Typography as Architectural Voice

Type is the last decision that still reads as a design decision.

Portfolio as Narrative · Typeface, Pairing, and Hierarchy

# Why Today Matters

## Type Speaks When You Are Not in the Room

- A reviewer reads your typography before they read a single word.
- **The typeface, the size hierarchy, and the spacing** have already said discipline or disorder.
- **Choosing type is a design decision,** and it should reinforce the position your project takes.
- Tonight you pick a pairing that fits your argument and test it on a spread.

WHAT THE PAGE SAYS FIRST

- **The typeface** the voice
- **The size hierarchy** the order
- **The spacing** the pace

*From Module 10: Typography and Type Hierarchy.*

# Learning Objectives

By the end of tonight, you will be able to:

1. **Match a typeface category** to what your project argues, using the four categories in the Typeface Guide.
2. **Build a pairing** of two families (three at most) that contrasts on purpose.
3. **Set a size hierarchy** and lock body text to the 12 pt baseline grid through your paragraph styles.
4. **Test the system** on your own content and in a second context, then roll it across the project.

CONCEPT

# One Sentence, Three Voices

Same words, three typefaces. Only the typeface changed.

MODERNIST

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

**Helvetica**

Reads as precise and quiet.

HUMANIST

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

**Avenir**

Reads as approachable and warm.

SERIF

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs.

**Palatino**

Reads as formal and considered.

*From the Flexible Framework statement (National Building Arts Center, St. Louis). Helvetica and Avenir are in the Typeface Guide. Palatino stands in for the editorial serifs.*

CONCEPT

# Four Typeface Categories

The Typeface Guide groups sixteen faces by what they signal.

| Category | What it signals | Typefaces |
|---|---|---|
| **Modernist Workhorses** | Neutral and precise | Helvetica, Futura, DIN, Univers |
| **Humanist & Contemporary** | Approachable and warm | Avenir, Söhne, Gill Sans, Circular |
| **Editorial & Stylistic** | Tuned to a specific design thesis | Neue Montreal, GT Alpina, Monolisk, Didot / Playfair Display, Minion Pro |
| **Functional & Display** | Built for drafting and scale | Century Gothic / DIN Pro, Tungsten, Roboto / Montserrat |

*Choose by what your project argues.*

CATEGORY 1 OF 4

# Modernist Workhorses

Neutral and precise

Rooted in the Swiss International Style and German engineering traditions, these faces put clarity first, so complex drawings and diagrams stay the focal point of the page.

### WHEN TO USE IT

Use these when the work is technical, drawing-heavy, or you want the type to stay out of the way.

| | BEST FOR | FREE ALTERNATIVE |
|---|---|---|
| **Helvetica** | Technical documentation, signage, resumes | Built-in system font |
| **Futura** | Headers, competition boards, titles | Jost |
| **DIN** | Annotating diagrams, design briefs | DM Sans |
| **Univers** | Complex layouts, long-form text | Inter |

CATEGORY 2 OF 4

# Humanist & Contemporary

Approachable and warm

Humanist faces add warmth to personal narratives, design philosophy statements, and digital portfolios.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these when the voice is personal: a statement, a studio story, an approachable portfolio.

| | BEST FOR | FREE ALTERNATIVE |
|---|---|---|
| **Avenir** | Personal statements, project descriptions | Nunito |
| **Söhne** | Modern branding | Space Grotesk |
| **Gill Sans** | Storytelling, narrative | Lato |
| **Circular** | Modern studio branding | Plus Jakarta Sans |

CATEGORY 3 OF 4

# Editorial & Stylistic

Tuned to a specific design thesis

Typography should reinforce the design thesis of the work it accompanies, from Brutalist materiality to classical refinement.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these when your project has a strong stylistic position and the type should share it.

| | BEST FOR | FREE ALTERNATIVE |
|---|---|---|
| **Neue Montreal** | High-end branding, editorial-style portfolios | Montserrat |
| **GT Alpina** | Academic and research-based portfolios | Source Serif 4 |
| **Monolisk** | Brutalist projects | Archivo Black |
| **Didot / Playfair** | Classical architecture, luxury | Playfair Display |
| **Minion Pro** | Academic writing, text-heavy work | Crimson Pro |

CATEGORY 4 OF 4

# Functional & Display

Built for drafting and scale

Made for legibility in CAD and BIM environments, and for impact on boards and exhibition displays.

WHEN TO USE IT

Use these for boards, large-format displays, and digital decks.

| | BEST FOR | FREE ALTERNATIVE |
|---|---|---|
| **Century Gothic / DIN Pro** | CAD and BIM environments | Poppins |
| **Tungsten** | Large-format displays | Oswald |
| **Roboto / Montserrat** | Digital portfolios, online decks | Roboto (free) |

CONCEPT

# Serif or Sans?

Neither is correct. The content and the medium decide.

## Serif

- **Minion Pro:** formal project statements, thesis documentation, classical analysis
- **Garamond:** body text and detailed technical description, academic portfolios
- **Bodoni:** project titles and high-contrast layouts

## Sans-serif

- **Helvetica:** body text, captions, annotations, digital portfolios
- **Futura:** section headers, conceptual portfolios, minimalist layouts
- **Montserrat:** digital presentations and contemporary projects

Rule of thumb: screen reading favors the clarity of a sans-serif. Print gives a serif room for subtlety and detail.

CONCEPT

# Three Tests Before You Commit

Run every candidate through these before it goes in a style.

1

### Assess the content

Traditional, academic work suits a serif. Contemporary, digital-focused work suits a sans-serif. Ask what the project argues.

2

### Test the context

What works for a caption can fail in a project statement. Test with your own text, never placeholder text.

3

### Consider the medium

Screen reading favors sans-serif clarity. Print allows more serif subtlety and detail. Most portfolios are read as PDFs on screen.

PAIRING

# Pairing Principles

One family for headings, one for reading.

### Two families, three at most

Mixing several serif families or several display faces signals indecision, not range.

### Vary inside the family

Use weight, italic, and light before you add a new typeface. A single family in two weights is a valid pairing.

### Contrast on purpose

A serif with a sans-serif, or two clearly different weights. Two faces that are almost alike look like a mistake.

### Readability first

Keep decorative faces off body text. Clarity beats expression in a professional portfolio.

PAIRING

# Four Pairings to Start From

From the Typeface Guide. Each has a free route if you do not have the commercial faces.

| Pairing | Character | Free route | Good for |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Futura + Minion Pro** | Geometric headings, humanist serif body | Jost + Crimson Pro | Modernist work with a written argument |
| **Helvetica + GT Alpina** | Neutral system with editorial warmth | Helvetica (built-in) + Source Serif 4 | Drawing-heavy, research-minded |
| **DIN + Source Serif 4** | Industrial precision, readable body text | DM Sans + Source Serif 4 | Technical and structural projects |
| **Söhne + Crimson Pro** | Contemporary headings, classic body | Space Grotesk + Crimson Pro | Studio or branding-forward portfolios |

*Pairings and free routes come from the Typeface Guide. The Good for column is a suggestion.*

HIERARCHY

# Size Hierarchy

Shown at the sizes you will use. If title and body look alike at arm's length, the contrast is too weak.

## Flexible Framework

National Building Arts Center, St. Louis, Missouri

The proposal introduces a modular timber structure that functions as a stable framework for diverse and shifting needs. Long spans, concrete, heavy timber, and ceramics reference the city's industrial architecture.

*Fig. 3 Axonometric of the timber frame with attachable gantry, shelving, and curtain components.*

*Titles step down in size and weight to body to caption. Each level is distinct.*

**Display titles**
24 to 48 pt

**Subtitles and section headers**
14 to 20 pt

**Body text**
9 to 11 pt

**Captions**
7 to 8 pt

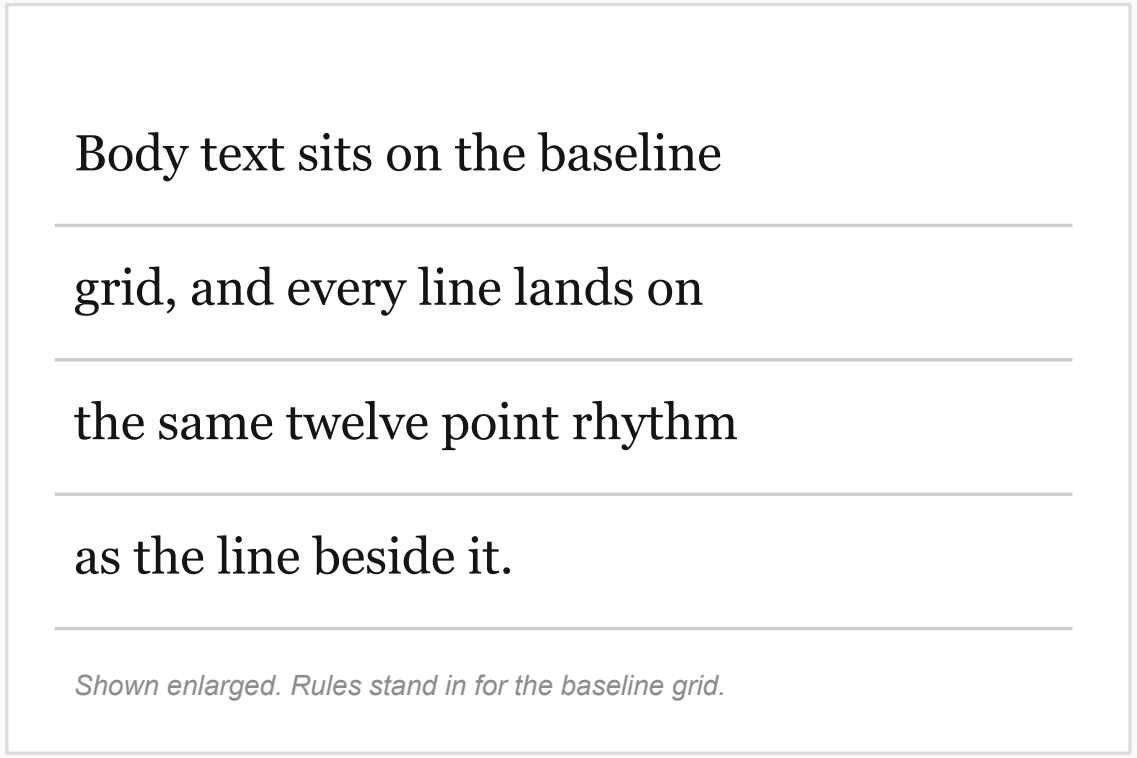
HIERARCHY

# Type Sits on the Grid

Your Session 05 baseline grid does the alignment work, if the paragraph styles ask it to.

### Body Text, 10 pt on 12 pt leading

- **Set it in the style:** Paragraph Styles > Body Text > Indents and Spacing > Align to Grid: All Lines.
- **Every line locks** to the 12 pt rhythm, so two columns on one spread land on the same lines.
- **Leading by role:** Body Text sits on the 12 pt grid. Titles and captions take their own leading.
- **Change the style, not the text.** One edit in the style updates every spread that uses it.




*Shown enlarged. Rules stand in for the baseline grid.*

HIERARCHY

# Where the Pairing Lives

Your four Session 04 paragraph styles are the home for the pairing.

| Style | Used for | Typeface slot | Size range |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Title** | Project titles, splash pages | Heading face | 24 to 48 pt |
| **Subtitle** | Running headers, accent lines | Heading face | 14 to 20 pt |
| **Body Text** | Descriptions, long captions | Body face | 9 to 11 pt (10/12 locks to the grid) |
| **Caption** | Credits and labels | Body face, italic or regular | 7 to 8 pt |

*Edit the four styles, then apply them. Hand-formatting a single text frame is how two spreads end up with different titles.*

RESOURCES

# Getting the Fonts

Check Adobe first, then Google Fonts, and only then a foundry.

### Adobe Fonts

fonts.adobe.com

- Minion Pro, Futura PT, and Helvetica Now are included with Creative Cloud.
- Activate them at no extra cost.
- Adobe offers 40 to 60% student discounts on Creative Cloud.

### Google Fonts

fonts.google.com

- Every free alternative in the guide lives here.
- Free for academic and professional work.
- Good for digital portfolios and PDFs.

### Commercial foundries

myfonts.com

- Klim (Söhne), Grilli Type (GT Alpina), Pangram Pangram (Neue Montreal, Monolisk), Monotype and MyFonts (DIN Next, Univers, Gill Sans, Avenir Next).
- Many offer 50 to 90% educational discounts. Ask.

RESOURCES

# Free Alternatives, Side by Side

Close in proportion, x-height, and character. All on Google Fonts unless noted.

| Replaces | Free font |
|---|---|
| **Helvetica** | Built-in system font |
| **Futura** | Jost |
| **DIN** | DM Sans |
| **Univers** | Inter |
| **Avenir** | Nunito |
| **Söhne** | Space Grotesk |
| **Gill Sans** | Lato |
| **Circular** | Plus Jakarta Sans |

| Replaces | Free font |
|---|---|
| **Neue Montreal** | Montserrat |
| **GT Alpina** | Source Serif 4 |
| **Monolisk** | Archivo Black |
| **Didot** | Playfair Display |
| **Minion Pro** | Crimson Pro |
| **Century Gothic** | Poppins |
| **Tungsten** | Oswald |
| **Roboto** | Roboto (same font) |

*Source: Architecture Portfolio Typeface Guide, pages 24 and 26.*

CONCEPT

# Common Mistakes, Quick Fixes

### Too many families

Cut to two, three at most. Use weight and italic for variety.

### A decorative face on body text

Keep display faces to titles. Body needs a reading face.

### Choosing from a specimen page

Set your own paragraph in it first. Test with your own text.

### Type competing with the drawings

Drawing-heavy spreads usually want a quiet, neutral face.

### Sizes that drift between spreads

Apply paragraph styles. Do not hand-format.

### Captions below 7 pt

Stay in the 7 to 8 pt range and check at 100% on screen.

HIERARCHY

# One System, Five Roles

The pairing has to cover every place type appears. Session 06 principles apply to type too.

| Role | Where it appears | Rule |
|---|---|---|
| **Display title** | Cover, project title pages | Heading face, 24 to 48 pt. The largest thing on the page. |
| **Section marker** | Running header, section dividers | Same position and style on every spread (information scent). |
| **Body** | Project statements, descriptions | Body face, 9 to 11 pt, locked to the 12 pt grid. |
| **Caption** | Under or beside every image | 7 to 8 pt, placed directly against its image (spatial contiguity). |
| **Labels and page numbers** | Every spread | One style, one place. A reviewer should never decode them. |

ACTIVITY

# Tonight's Activity

Open your project file from Session 06. Choose a pairing, put it in your paragraph styles, and test it on one spread.

- Name your category and why: what does the project argue?
- Pick one heading face and one body face. Three families at most.
- Install the fonts (Adobe Fonts or Google Fonts).
- Update Title, Subtitle, Body Text, and Caption. No hand-formatting.
- Keep Body Text at 10 pt on 12 pt, Align to Grid: All Lines.
- Test on one spread of your project, then in a second context.

TIMING

## 30 minutes

Then 20 minutes of peer review using tonight's questions.

DUE THURSDAY, OCT 22

Your typeface system applied across every spread, plus two candidate title-page treatments. Submit the .indd and a PDF.

DISCUSSION

# Peer Review Questions

Twenty minutes in small groups. Look at each person's tested spread in turn.

1. Can you read the hierarchy from across the room, or do title and body look alike?
2. Do the two faces contrast enough to look intentional, or do they look almost the same?
3. Does the pairing match the tone of what the project argues? Grads: does it match the Red Thread from Session 03?
4. Does body text sit on the baseline grid with no drift between lines?
5. Name one specific change before moving to the next screen.

# Choose Once, Apply Everywhere

Pick a category, build the pairing, put it in the four paragraph styles, and apply it to every spread.

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**OPTIONAL READING**

“How a Typeface Takes a Position”, the history and reasoning behind the categories.

**NEXT SESSION**

Session 08: Color, Representation & the Photographed Model